This tends to support a belief that increasingly the violence in Rakhine is not directly under the control of the Myanmar authorities but is following local dynamics. This is not to absolve the regime, which has stoked up hatred over forty years and does little, if anything, to constrain the actions of Rakhine extremists.

The wave of violence started on 22 October and lasted a week. Many attacks started by burning the local community mosques and then burning houses forcing the local Rohingyas to flee. Some witnesses insisted that the initial attacks were not carried out by locals they recognised but by people who came into the community from outside.[37] On 23 October there were coordinated attacks in villages in Mrauk-U, Minbya, Kyauk Pyu, and Pauktaw districts. This time, however, the target was all Muslims, regardless of ethnicity, and the Kaman (who have legal citizenship) were also attacked in the coastal region of Kyauk Pyu.[38] The ensuing violence was not completely one-sided and, in some places, Rakhine Buddhists were killed as Rohingya and Kaman villagers defended their communities.

One of the worst incidents was at the village of Yan Thei on 23 October, where a massacre commenced at 6.30 AM. The attack was clearly prepared and followed on from the events of the previous day, when the local police (the Lon Thein) had disarmed the local Rohingyas of sticks and other crude weapons. One survivor presented evidence on the role of the police:

> [W]e went outside the village [when thousands of Arakanese approached], and then the Lon Thein told us to go back inside the village and then they took the sticks from our hands. First the [Lon Thein] security told us, 'Do not do anything, we will protect you, we will save you,' so we trusted them. But later they broke that promise. The Arakanese beat and killed us very easily. The security did not protect us from them.[39]

Other survivors have stated that the local police actually participated in the attack and opened fire on villagers. There is no independent evidence for this, but all the eyewitness reports support the claim that the villagers were promised protection from the Arakanese mob and then abandoned to their fates. Around 5 PM the army finally intervened, although by that stage most of the violence was over. Among the dead were twenty-eight children, thirteen of whom were aged under five, who had been hacked to death.[40]

Elsewhere it appears as if the security forces were definitely involved in the violence. There are several reports that in Kyauk Pyu on 23 October the army shot three young Muslims.[41] But the role of the army, as it had been in June, was not consistent. In places, the military did prevent violence or